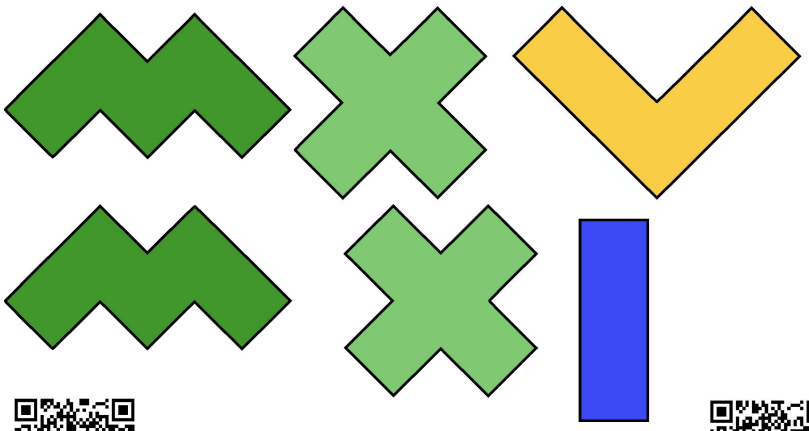
MathsJam Shout

February 2026
Various

Puzzle

2026 Jigsaw

George Sicherman (of dice fame) has designed a puzzle to celebrate the year 2026, aka MMXXVI. Print it onto card, cut out and try to fit the pieces together.



Printable (A4):
sicherman.net/2026/2026-a4.pdf

Printable (Letter):
sicherman.net/2026/2026.pdf

Trick The Floating Card

From **Donald Bell**

Shuffle a full deck of cards and then divide it into three (nearly) equal chunks, face down. Choose any chunk and turn it over, so that its bottom card becomes visible. This will be our "control card". Its name can have as few as 10 letters (like S-I-X-O-F-C-L-U-B-S) or as many as 15 (like Q-U-E-E-N-O-F-D-I-A-M-O-N-D-S).

Choose another chunk, pick it up and look at its bottom card. This will be our "floater card". We don't need the third chunk.

Turn this chunk back over, and deal cards one by one on to the table from it, to spell out the name of the 'control card' (one card per letter). When you have finished, drop the cards still in your hand on top of the pile on the table. You can, if you like, verify that the "floater card" has not yet reached the top of the chunk.

Do the deal one more time. The floater card has not yet reached the top. Then do the deal a third time. Now the floater card HAS reached the top.

How does this trick work? Can you explain?

Fix 2026 Equations

Courtesy of **Antwerp MathsJam**, Belgium

Use the symbols, with the numbers in the order given, to make the equation balance.

9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1 = 2026

add in: ( ) × × × + + + + −

Or, for a bigger challenge:

10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1 = 2026

add in: ((( ))) × × × + + + + + +

MathsJam Shout is a monthly sheet of ideas for activities to do at a MathsJam night. It's created using suggestions from a different MathsJam each month, and if you'd like to submit suggestions for a month in the future, email **katie@mathsjam.com**

Maths Jam is a monthly opportunity for like-minded self-confessed maths enthusiasts to get together in a pub and share stuff they like. Puzzles, games, problems, or just anything they think is cool or interesting. Monthly Maths Jam nights happen in over 70 locations around the world, on the second-to-last Tuesday of each month. To find your nearest Maths Jam, visit the website at **mathsjam.com.**

The Colonel's
M M X X V I
Puzzle

Cut out the six pieces and place them in the red interior of the tray without overlapping. Pieces with the same shape may not touch. The pieces may not form holes.

Col. George Sicherman
2025-12-28



